

Strategic Analysis of ESG Disclosures and Corporate Governance for Hankook & Company (000240.KS)

Company Identification and Operational Context

The entity identified by the South Korean stock ticker 000240.KS is Hankook & Company Co., Ltd., which functions as the operating holding company for the Hankook & Company Group.¹ Historically known as Hankook Technology Group Co., Ltd., the firm underwent a formal rebranding in December 2020 to align its corporate identity with a broader vision of becoming a global "Smart Energy Solution Provider".¹ The company is headquartered at 286 Pangyo-ro, Bundang-gu, Seongnam-si, Gyeonggi-do, South Korea, within the Pangyo Technoplex, a strategic hub for South Korea's high-tech and automotive innovation sectors.¹

The primary business activities of Hankook & Company are bifurcated between its role as a holding company managing a vast network of subsidiaries—most notably the world’s seventh-largest tire manufacturer, Hankook Tire & Technology—and its own direct industrial operations.⁴ Its internal operational unit, the "ES Business Headquarters" (formerly the independent entity AtlasBX), specializes in the development and manufacture of high-performance energy solutions.² This unit produces lead-acid batteries for a variety of applications, including the automotive, commercial vehicle, leisure, and industrial sectors.¹ The company’s sector classification is generally listed under Industrials, with a specific industry focus on Auto Components and Machinery.¹

Attribute	Verified Information	Primary Source(s)
Legal Name	Hankook & Company Co., Ltd.	¹
Ticker Symbol	000240.KS	¹
Headquarters	286 Pangyo-ro, Bundang-gu, Seongnam-si, Gyeonggi-do, South Korea	¹
Primary Business	Holding Company & Energy	¹

	Solutions (Lead-acid batteries)	
Sector/Industry	Industrials / Auto Components	¹
Market Segment	KOSPI (South Korea)	¹
Key Subsidiary	Hankook Tire & Technology (Ticker: 161390.KS)	⁴

The identification of Hankook & Company is substantiated by various financial data providers and official exchange listings, including Investing.com, Bloomberg, and Reuters, which consistently link the 000240.KS ticker to the holding company.¹ While there is often a degree of overlap in public perception between the holding company and its prominent tire subsidiary, this report focuses specifically on the sustainability and governance profile of the holding entity 000240.KS, while acknowledging that many ESG initiatives are implemented via a group-wide "ESG Steering Committee" that spans all major affiliates.²

ESG Report Timeline Analysis (2014–2023)

The sustainability disclosure history of Hankook & Company reflects the broader evolution of the South Korean corporate landscape from traditional philanthropy and corporate social responsibility (CSR) to a rigorous, data-driven Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) framework. The group has maintained a consistent reporting schedule, publishing annual sustainability reports since 2010, with the 16th edition released in mid-2024.¹¹

Early Standardization and Climate Awareness (2014–2017)

During the early part of this decade, the company focused on establishing a baseline for transparency and gaining recognition from international rating agencies. This period was characterized by the initial adoption of the Carbon Disclosure Project (CDP) and the inclusion in the Dow Jones Sustainability Index (DJSI).

In 2014, the company was awarded the "Carbon Management Sector Honors" by CDP Korea, a recognition it would repeat in 2015, 2017, and 2018.¹² This demonstrated an early organizational commitment to measuring and disclosing carbon footprints, a critical move for an industrial manufacturer heavily reliant on energy-intensive chemical and lead-processing operations. Simultaneously, the company launched the "Laufenn" brand to diversify its product portfolio with a focus on long-term sustainability and market resilience.⁵

By 2016, the group had achieved a major infrastructure milestone with the inauguration of the

Hankook Technodome, a state-of-the-art R&D center designed to centralize future technology development.¹³ The facility was subsequently awarded LEED Gold certification by the U.S. Green Building Council, validating the group's efforts to minimize the environmental impact of its physical footprint.² This year also marked the company's first inclusion in the DJSI World, an indicator of its performance relative to global peers in ethics, social contribution, and environmental management.¹³

Policy Formalization and Circular Economy Shift (2018–2020)

The 2018–2020 period saw the company moving from disclosure to policy setting. In 2018, the group launched two pivotal initiatives: the "Sustainable Natural Rubber Policy" and the "E. Circle" strategy.¹⁴ The rubber policy aimed to address biodiversity and human rights concerns in the supply chain, while E. Circle established a circular economy framework to manage products from design through to disposal.¹⁵ Recognition continued to grow, with the group being named to the CDP Supplier Engagement Leaderboard in 2018, highlighting its influence on upstream sustainability.¹²

In 2020, the company reached a new level of external validation, receiving a "Platinum" grade in the EcoVadis ESG evaluation, placing it in the top 1% of the global tire industry.⁵ This achievement was supported by the group's expansion into the electric vehicle (EV) market, notably becoming the original equipment (OE) supplier for high-performance electric cars like the Porsche Taycan.⁵ The rebranding to Hankook & Company in December 2020 served as the final act of this period, consolidating the energy business under a unified holding structure to prepare for the subsequent merger with AtlasBX.¹

Integration, Merger, and Science-Based Alignment (2021–2023)

The most recent phase (2021–2023) is defined by the 2021 merger between Hankook & Company and AtlasBX Corp.² This structural shift led to the creation of the ESG Factbook 2022 and 2023, which report on the holding company's direct operational performance for the first time.² A specialized ESG Committee was established under the Board of Directors in 2021 to ensure that sustainability strategies were integrated into the highest level of corporate governance.¹⁵

In 2022, the group made its most ambitious environmental commitment to date by joining the Science Based Targets initiative (SBTi) and submitting its greenhouse gas (GHG) reduction targets.¹⁴ These targets were officially validated by the SBTi in 2023, making Hankook the first in the Korean tire industry to have science-based near-term 2030 goals and a 2050 Net Zero target.¹⁶ Furthermore, the company published its "Corporate Governance Charter" in May 2022 to strengthen transparency and ethical standards.¹⁴ The 2023 reporting cycle saw the adoption of the double materiality assessment, aligning the company with the European Sustainability Reporting Standards (ESRS) and the Taskforce on Nature-related Financial Disclosures (TNFD)

LEAP approach for biodiversity risk management.¹⁵

Year	Key ESG Milestone	Significance	Source
2014	CDP Carbon Management Sector Honors	Early adoption of carbon transparency standards.	12
2016	Technodome LEED Gold Certification	Validation of sustainable infrastructure.	2
2016	DJSI World Inclusion	First recognition as a global sustainability leader.	13
2018	Sustainable Natural Rubber Policy	Engagement with complex supply chain social risks.	15
2018	E. Circle Strategy	Formal launch of circular economy initiatives.	15
2020	EcoVadis Platinum Grade	Placement in the top 1% of global industry peers.	5
2021	ESG Committee Establishment	Board-level oversight of sustainability risks.	15
2022	Corporate Governance Charter	Codification of ethical management principles.	14

2023	SBTi Validation (2050 Net Zero)	Alignment with the Paris Agreement's 1.5°C target.	¹⁶
2023	Double Materiality Assessment	Compliance with upcoming EU disclosure regulations.	¹⁵

Environmental Leadership and the Circular Economy

Hankook & Company's environmental strategy is predicated on the dual necessity of reducing the carbon intensity of its energy solutions and implementing a robust circular economy for its battery and tire products. The company characterizes this approach as the "Green Survival" era, where ecological responsibility is not a secondary objective but a prerequisite for corporate longevity.²

Decarbonization and SBTi Targets

The core of the environmental management system is the 2050 Net Zero roadmap, which is built upon the Science Based Targets initiative (SBTi) framework. The group has committed to reducing its Scope 1 and 2 emissions—those directly generated by manufacturing and indirectly through purchased energy—by 46.2% by 2030, using a 2019 baseline.¹⁶ More critically, it targets a 27.5% reduction in Scope 3 emissions across its value chain by 2030.¹⁶

These targets are implemented through several mechanisms:

1. **Energy Efficiency:** In 2023 alone, the company conducted 79 specific energy-saving activities, resulting in a 4.45% year-on-year reduction in manufacturing emissions.²¹ These activities include the deployment of high-efficiency industrial equipment and the optimization of thermal management systems.
2. **Renewable Energy Transition:** The group is actively reviewing transitions to clean energy across its global production sites, including those in South Korea, China, Hungary, and the United States.¹⁰
3. **GHG Database Management:** The ESG Steering Committee has established a group-wide database to monitor emissions data across all subsidiaries, ensuring that disclosures remain accurate and verifiable by third parties such as the Korea Productivity Center.²

Circularity in the Battery Sector (ES Business)

As a primary manufacturer of lead-acid batteries, Hankook & Company operates in an industry that is inherently suited for circular material flows. The primary components of these

batteries—lead, polypropylene (PP), and sulfuric acid—are almost entirely recyclable.²

The company’s circular economy system for batteries focuses on:

- **Material Recovery:** Using recycled lead is significantly more efficient than using primary lead mined from the earth. The process reduces energy consumption and minimizes the greenhouse gas footprint of the raw material procurement phase.²
- **Waste Mitigation:** Hankook & Company has set a medium-term goal to reduce waste emissions from its production sites by 30% by 2030, compared to a 2023 baseline.¹⁰ This is achieved by increasing the rate of scrap recycling within the manufacturing process.
- **Eco-Friendly Packaging:** The company utilizes recycled materials for battery cases and packaging, further reducing the reliance on virgin plastics.²

The E. Circle Strategy in Tire Manufacturing

The tire subsidiary applies the E. Circle strategy across the entire product life cycle to ensure sustainable material use and waste management. This strategy is divided into five distinct stages: Design, Raw Material Procurement, Manufacturing, Use, and Disposal.¹⁶

Stage	ESG Initiative	Objective
Design	Chemical pre-screening & Lightweighting	Prevent hazardous substance use; improve fuel efficiency.
Procurement	Sustainable Raw Materials (ISCC PLUS)	Traceability of bio-based oils, resins, and recycled PET.
Manufacturing	Resource Recovery	Minimize water intake and energy use in plants.
Use	High Wear Resistance	Extend product service life to reduce waste frequency.
Disposal	Upcycling (re:move)	Convert waste tires into secondary raw materials or

		shoes/longboards.
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The company has successfully commercialized tires incorporating 77% sustainable materials, including chemically recycled PET cords and carbon black derived from tire pyrolysis.¹⁵ This innovation is supported by the ISCC PLUS certification, which ensures that the sustainable content of the tires is verified through a rigorous mass-balance accounting system.¹⁶

Social Responsibility and Supply Chain Integrity

The social dimension of Hankook & Company’s ESG strategy emphasizes human rights, employee safety, and the ethical management of a complex global supply chain. The company has explicitly endorsed the 10 principles of the UN Global Compact (UNGC) and aligns its activities with the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).⁹

Human Rights and Labor Management

The company has established a formal Human Rights Management System that applies to all employees and business partners. This system is designed to prevent abuses and ensure a fair, non-discriminatory workplace.⁹ Key pillars of this policy include:

- **Prohibition of Forced and Child Labor:** Strict adherence to international labor standards, with regular internal audits to verify compliance at all business sites.⁹
- **Freedom of Association:** The company guarantees the right to collective bargaining and maintains labor-management councils to foster a win-win relationship between the workforce and leadership.⁹
- **Diversity and Inclusion:** Policies are in place to prevent discrimination based on gender, age, or background, and the company actively promotes "Work-life harmony" through various enrichment programs.²⁰

Supply Chain Risk Management and Natural Rubber

For a global mobility company, the social risks inherent in the procurement of raw materials like natural rubber and conflict minerals are significant. Hankook & Company manages these risks through its "Sustainable Natural Rubber Policy," which aims to improve the livelihoods of smallholder farmers and prevent deforestation.¹⁴

The company's supply chain governance includes:

1. **Supplier ESG Assessments:** Regular diagnosis and evaluation of environmental and social risks for key suppliers, including audits for labor practices and environmental compliance.²
2. **Conflict Minerals Policy:** Strict guidelines to ensure that minerals used in battery production—such as lead and other additives—are not sourced from conflict zones that

fund human rights violations.⁹

3. **EUDR Compliance:** In response to the European Union Deforestation Regulation (EUDR), the group has established a dedicated committee to monitor its natural rubber supply chain and implement reporting protocols to ensure zero-deforestation in its products.¹⁵

Community Engagement and Social Innovation

Hankook & Company views social contribution as an investment in the resilience of the communities where it operates. Notable projects include:

- **Mobility Support:** The company provides vehicle and tire sharing services to local NGOs and underprivileged communities to enhance mobility and access to essential services.¹⁹
- **Hearty Social Housing:** An initiative that provides affordable housing solutions for low-income citizens, addressing urban social inequality.²³
- **Hankook Donggeurami Partners:** A subsidiary established as a standard workplace for the disabled, providing stable employment and vocational training to socially vulnerable groups.²³

Corporate Governance: Structure, Conflict, and Reform

Governance is the area where Hankook & Company has faced the most significant challenges, primarily due to internal family disputes and legal issues involving its leadership. Despite these controversies, the company has implemented structural reforms to align with modern corporate standards.

Governance Structure and Board Oversight

The company is governed by a Board of Directors (BOD) that includes several specialized committees to ensure checks and balances.²³ Since 2021, the Board has operated an ESG Committee to specifically manage sustainability policy and long-term targets.¹⁵

Other critical committees include:

- **Audit Committee:** Composed primarily of independent directors, it oversees the internal accounting management system and conducts annual evaluations of the CEO.²³
- **Internal Transactions Committee:** Tasked with ensuring transparency and fairness in dealings between group affiliates to prevent unfair wealth transfers—a historical concern in South Korean conglomerates.²³
- **Sustainability Committee:** Approved in late 2024, this committee monitors ESG-related risks and evaluates the company's progress against its Net Zero goals.²³

The Cho Family Feud and Hostile Takeover Attempts

A defining feature of the company's governance narrative is the ongoing management rights dispute among the children of Honorary Chairman Cho Yang-rai. The conflict originated in 2020 when the patriarch transferred his entire 23.59% stake to his youngest son, Cho Hyun-beom, effectively bypassing his elder son, Cho Hyun-sik, and his daughters.⁸

In December 2023, the dispute reached a critical point when the private equity firm MBK Partners launched a hostile tender offer for Hankook & Company shares.⁸ MBK Partners allied with the elder brother, Cho Hyun-sik, offering 20,000 KRW per share in an attempt to secure management control and address what they described as a "crisis situation" in corporate governance.⁸ The tender offer ultimately failed after the younger brother, Chairman Cho Hyun-beom, secured support from "friendly forces," including the Hyosung Group and the patriarch himself, bringing the faction's stake to approximately 45.87%.²⁴

Legal Controversies and Leadership Stability

Chairman Cho Hyun-beom has faced significant legal challenges that have impacted the group's reputation and ESG ratings. In 2023, he was indicted on charges of embezzlement and breach of trust totaling approximately 20 billion KRW.⁸ These issues were reflected in the company's governance score from the Korea ESG Institute (KCGS), which assigned a "D" grade to the tire subsidiary in 2023.²²

In May 2024, the situation escalated when the Seoul Central District Court sentenced Chairman Cho to three years in prison, leading to his legal detention.²⁶ This leadership void has raised concerns within the industry regarding the group's ability to respond to external uncertainties, such as fluctuating U.S. tariff policies and the need for continuous R&D investment in the "S.T.R.E.A.M" future growth portfolio.¹⁷

Governance Factor	Description	Potential ESG Impact	Source
Sibling Conflict	Struggle between Cho brothers for group control.	Strategic instability; tender offer risk.	8
Judicial Risk	Chairman's detention for embezzlement/breach of trust.	Lowered ESG ratings; potential "owner void."	22
ESG Committee	Established in 2021	Improved structural	15

	to oversee sustainability.	oversight.	
Shareholder Policy	Revised Articles of Incorporation for dividend predictability.	Enhanced shareholder transparency.	11

ESG Rating History and Rating Agency Assessments

The divergence between Hankook & Company's environmental achievements and its governance challenges is clearly visible in the ratings provided by domestic and international agencies. These ratings are used by institutional investors to assess the risk profile of the 000240.KS ticker.

KCGS (Korea Institute of Corporate Governance and Sustainability)

The KCGS ratings are the most influential benchmark for ESG performance in South Korea. Hankook & Company has shown a fluctuating trend, with its Integrated grade often weighed down by the Governance component.²⁰

- **2024 Rating:** The company achieved an Integrated grade of **B+**, with individual scores of **B+** for Environment, **A** for Social, and **B** for Governance.²⁰
- **2023 Rating:** The integrated grade was also **B+**, though the Governance component was slightly higher at **B+** before the full impact of the Chairman's legal detention was realized in later evaluations.²⁰
- **2021 Peak:** In 2021, following the merger and the establishment of the ESG Committee, the company reached an Integrated grade of **A**, demonstrating its potential when governance risks are perceived to be under control.²⁰

International Indices and Certifications

Despite local governance concerns, the group's operational excellence in sustainability has earned it high marks on the global stage:

- **DJSI World:** The tire subsidiary has been included in the DJSI World for seven consecutive years (2016–2023), a feat achieved by only a small fraction of global companies.¹⁸
- **CDP:** In 2024, the company received an **A** score in the Climate Change category, reflecting its high-quality disclosures and scientific approach to carbon management.¹²
- **EcoVadis:** The group maintains a **Platinum** medal, placing it in the top 1% of the automotive components industry globally.⁵
- **S&P Global ESG Score:** The company is assessed under the "Auto Components" industry category, with scores used to determine inclusion in various S&P ESG indices.⁷

Index/Rating	Entity	Most Recent Status	Source
KCGS Integrated	Hankook & Company	B+ (2024)	20
DJSI World	Hankook Tire & Tech	Included (7th consecutive year)	18
CDP Climate	Hankook Tire & Tech	A (2024)	22
EcoVadis	Hankook Tire & Tech	Platinum (Top 1%)	5
LACP Spotlight	ESG Report 2022/23	Gold Award	22

Reference Table with Credibility Assessment

The following table evaluates the sources used in this analysis according to the specified credibility scoring guidelines.

#	Reference (APA 7th edition format)	Source Type	Credibility Score (0–10)	Justification for Score	Relevance to Query
1	Hankook & Company. (2024). <i>ESG Factbook 2023</i> .	Primary (Corporate)	10	Official company filing with verified quantitative data.	High: Primary data for 000240.KS.

2	Hankook Tire & Technology. (2024). <i>ESG Report 2024-25.</i>	Primary (Corporate)	10	Audited report with third-party assurance from KPC.	High: Comprehensive group ESG data.
3	S&P Global Sustainable1. (2024). <i>Hankook & Company Co., Ltd. ESG Score.</i>	Secondary (Rating Agency)	9	Global leader in ESG data with transparent methodology.	High: Independent performance evaluation.
4	JoongAng Daily. (2023). <i>Family feud continues at Hankook & Company.</i>	Secondary (News)	8	Reputable editorial standards; detailed reporting on disputes.	High: Context on governance controversies.
5	KCGS. (2024). <i>ESG Rating Archive.</i>	Secondary (Rating Agency)	9	Primary local authority for Korean market ESG benchmarks.	High: Historical rating data.
6	SBTi. (2023). <i>Validated Target Dashboard: Hankook Tire.</i>	Secondary (NGO)	9	Scientific authority on corporate climate commitments.	High: Verification of Net Zero claims.

7	Investing.com. (2024). <i>Hankook & Company Profile</i> .	Secondary (Financial Data)	8	Standard market data provider for legal and sector info.	High: Identification of legal name and ticker.
8	Financial News. (2024, May 29). <i>Cho Hyun-beom sentenced to 3 years</i> .	Secondary (News)	8	Verified reporting on court proceedings and judicial outcomes.	High: Governance controversy verification.
9	LACP. (2023). <i>Spotlight Awards: Hankook ESG Report</i> .	Secondary (Awards)	7	Professional communication organization evaluation.	Medium: Recognition of report quality.
10	USGBC. (2016). <i>Technodome LEED Gold Certification</i> .	Secondary (NGO)	10	Official database for green building certification.	Medium: Environmental infrastructure data.

Transparency and Limitations

While every effort has been made to provide a comprehensive analysis of Hankook & Company (000240.KS), certain limitations inherent in the available data must be acknowledged:

1. **Subsidiary vs. Parent Data:** There is a significant amount of "reporting overlap" between the holding company (000240.KS) and its primary subsidiary, Hankook Tire & Technology (161390.KS).² While this report explicitly identifies the holding company, many of the group's highest-profile ESG awards (e.g., DJSI World, EcoVadis Platinum) are legally attributed to the tire subsidiary, though the holding company manages the ESG Strategy Committee that oversees these efforts.²

2. **Unverified Claims:** Claims regarding the long-term impact of the Chairman's detention on future R&D spending are inherently speculative and have been labeled as "interpretive analysis" or "industry concern" rather than verified facts.²⁶
3. **Knowledge Cutoff and Real-Time Data:** The data reflected in this report is current through the 2024 reporting cycle and includes significant developments through early 2025.¹ However, the management rights dispute is highly fluid, and changes in share ownership or judicial rulings occurring after the production of this report may alter the governance profile of the company.
4. **Assurance Limitations:** While the 2024 ESG Report for the tire subsidiary includes a full independent assurance statement from the Korea Productivity Center (KPC), the "ESG Factbook" for the holding company is sometimes published as a preliminary or supplementary document without the same level of exhaustive third-party verification for every specific data point.²

For continued independent monitoring, users should refer to:

- **The South Korean Electronic Disclosure System (DART):** For all official regulatory filings (<http://dart.fss.or.kr>).
- **CDP Search Portal:** For updated climate and water security scores (<https://www.cdp.net/en/responses>).
- **Hankook & Company Investor Relations:** For the latest ESG Factbooks and governance charters (<https://www.hankookandcompany.com/en/ir/governance.do>).

Conclusion and Strategic Outlook

The analysis of Hankook & Company (000240.KS) reveals a corporation at a strategic crossroads. On one hand, the company has demonstrated world-class performance in the environmental and social pillars of ESG. Its commitment to science-based targets, industry-first certifications (ISCC PLUS), and the implementation of a circular economy for its battery and tire businesses position it as a leader in the global transition to sustainable mobility.¹⁵ The integration of the battery business into the holding company has created a unified "Smart Energy Solution Provider" identity that is well-aligned with the growth of the electric vehicle market.²

On the other hand, the company is burdened by severe governance risks that threaten its long-term valuation and strategic agility. The "second brothers' conflict" over management rights and the legal detention of Chairman Cho Hyun-beom for financial crimes create a persistent instability that external rating agencies like KCGS have flagged with low governance scores.⁸ While the company has implemented structural improvements, such as the Board-level ESG Committee and the Corporate Governance Charter, these reforms must contend with the volatility of the controlling family's internal dynamics.¹⁴

The future outlook for Hankook & Company depends on whether the institutionalized ESG

management systems can continue to function effectively during the current leadership void. If the group can successfully navigate the owner's legal challenges while continuing to meet its 2030 SBTi targets, it may overcome the "governance discount" and solidify its position as a sustainable industrial powerhouse. However, if the management dispute escalates into another hostile takeover attempt or leads to strategic stagnation, the company's impressive environmental achievements may be overshadowed by its governance failures.

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